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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): The Role Of Paternal Kinsmen

When a man or woman dies, a portion of the estate is inherited by the *basyanausi*. These must take part in the funeral rites and when they depart they are said to take with them the guardian spirit which they gave at the naming of the child. In this way they acknowledge that theirs is but a lifetime's interest in their child and that he is primarily a member of his matrilineal group which inherits his spirit. When a divination is sought to find the cause of death, representatives of the *basyanausi* must join with representatives of the *basimukowa*. Since both are his heirs they are the ones who profit from the death, and it is within either group that the source of the deadly sorcery is likely to be found.

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These rights and obligations vest in the *basyanausi* as a whole, but the generational principle which operates within a matrilineal group also affects its relations with its 'children'. A child is bound primarily to its own father and through him to his generation whether of the same branch or not. It is to this generation that a person owes respect and to its members he turns for assistance. Those not of this generation are joking partners and equals, and would be treated as 'fathers' only in the absence of any member of the paternal generation.

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Kinship terms reflect the generational alinement. All those whom the father calls 'brother', including his mother's mother's brother and his sister's daughter's son, are 'fathers'. Their sisters, with the exception of the father's mother's mothers, were called 'father's sister', but today the term for 'mother' has replaced the old term. Males and females alike call a brother's son by the term used for own child. All children of males of the same generation call each other 'brother' or 'sister'. They have exactly the same status with reference to their *basyanausi*, for the same generation has responsibility for them all.

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The same generation of *basyanausi* also has responsibility for and authority over the generation of their sisters' sons, but this authority is different in kind from that which it exercises over its children. Children and sisters' children therefore are in somewhat of an equivocal position in relation to one another. They call one another 'cross-cousin' and have a relationship of licensed familiarity. Bilateral cross-cousin marriages were formerly highly approved and although coming into some disrepute at the present  56 time are still common. Those who stand as children and sister's children to the same generation of a matrilineal group are therefore likely to be brothers-in-law and sisters-in-law, or husbands and wives, as well as cross-cousins.

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Human Relations Area Files
755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511
General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu
Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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